Sales Competition Strategy

From Bookings to Deals. Build for the Next Ten Hires.

Strategy meeting led by Corie Dawson, Director · June 2026 · Marketing Sweet

PURPOSE Internal strategy note covering the redesign of the sales competition — what changed, why it changed, and the leadership principles underneath it.

1. Why redesign the competition

The prior promotion paid out a flat amount per booking attended. It worked — bookings grew, attendance lifted, the lead-gen team responded to the incentive. But the structure carried a side effect the team noticed themselves: reps got hungry for bookings that attended, not bookings that closed. The incentive was rewarding the wrong end of the funnel.

> *"It did shift our mindset more into just getting them to attend. We wanted them to attend, but didn't care if the deal went through."*

The redesign rebalances the incentive to point at the right outcome — deals — while keeping the structural advantages of the booking bonus for recruitment and onboarding. The new design is built for the team that exists today and the next ten hires the team will absorb over the next year.

2. The metric shift — from bookings to deals

This is the central principle. The headline number is no longer bookings per day. It's deals per day, and money produced per day. Bookings stay relevant — they are the path to deals — but they are no longer the win condition. The whole design points at deals.

OLD INCENTIVE · BOOKINGS	NEW INCENTIVE · DEALS
Reps focus on getting buyers to attend	Reps focus on getting buyers to close
Bookings without quality pass through	Bookings are qualified harder, deals lift
The win condition is volume	The win condition is conversion
Lead-gen and closers measured separately	Both teams aligned on the same end metric
Easy to game	Harder to game — closing is real work

3. Keep the booking bonus — but as a safety net, not the main event

The team discussed removing the per-booking payment entirely. The decision: keep it. Not because it's the right ongoing incentive for experienced reps — they would happily lose it for a larger deal bonus — but because it is the most powerful recruitment lever available.

> *"Think about the first day cold-calling. The safety net is what makes the role attractive to people who have never done sales. The bonus structure is part of the recruitment pitch — not just the daily incentive."*

How the safety net earns its place:

- New starters need wins inside their first week. The booking bonus produces those wins on day one — before they've learned to close.
- Recruitment conversations get sharper. "Base wage plus per-booking bonus plus deal commission" sells better than "base wage plus deal commission only."
- It creates a soft landing for veteran reps who hit a rough patch. The bonus is the floor under their week — they always have something to point at.
- Removing it later (when a rep has graduated) is easier than introducing it later. Start with it, allow reps to opt out of it as they mature.

4. The deal bonus — sized to the deal

The new headline bonus is paid per closed deal, with the amount sized to the deal value. The principle: a small deal pays a smaller bonus, a large deal pays a larger one. Reps don't chase every booking equally — they chase the ones with the biggest payoff at the close.

The structural advantages of a sliding scale:

- Discourages reps from closing low-margin deals just to clock a number.
- Encourages preparation. Reps spend more time on bookings they expect to convert well.
- Aligns rep behaviour with agency profitability. Big deals matter more — the bonus reflects that.
- Removes the ceiling effect. Reps have a reason to keep pushing on a deal that could become a bigger one.

5. The wheel — gamification for variable reinforcement

The headline gamification mechanic. Reps who hit qualifying thresholds (three consecutive closed deals, or the team hits 10 deals in a week) earn the right to spin a wheel. The wheel contains a mix of reward types — and the buyer doesn't know what they'll land on. That uncertainty is the entire point.

> *"Variable rewards beat predictable rewards. The brain treats a known $100 bonus differently from a chance at a $250 cash or a mystery prize or a team experience. The uncertainty is what makes it sticky."*

The reward mix on the wheel:

REWARD TYPE	WHAT IT IS · WHY IT'S ON THE WHEEL
TEAM FOOD	Lunch out, dinner, drinks — for the whole team. Builds shared experience.
TEAM EXPERIENCE	Gold class movie, escape room, go-karting.

REWARD TYPE	WHAT IT IS · WHY IT'S ON THE WHEEL
	Memorable, shared, off-the-clock.
CASH	Direct deposit. Personal. The straightforward reward.
MYSTERY PRIZE	Sealed envelope. Could be small, could be the biggest of the lot. Excitement spike.
WILD CARD	Double commission on the next deal. Massive upside if you've got a big deal in the pipeline.
BOOBY TRAP	A pack of lollies. Low-end novelty prize. There to make the highs feel higher.

6. The booby trap — why the lows matter

The most counter-intuitive element of the design. A small share of the wheel is a deliberately low reward — a pack of lollies. The natural instinct is to remove it. The reasoning for keeping it: variable reinforcement requires a downside. Without the possibility of landing on something small, the wheel's highs lose their relative thrill. The booby trap isn't a punishment — it's a contrast lever.

> *"You need to have some lows in there. That's the thing of having the highest — you need the contrast. It's not punishment. It's the novelty that makes the rest of the wheel feel like a win."*

The principle, generalised:

- Predictable upside fades. The brain adapts to it and stops responding.
- Variable upside (mixed in with downside) keeps the dopamine system engaged.
- The booby trap also resets ego — a rep who landed on the small prize last week works harder this week.
- Keep the low low — but light. A pack of lollies, not nothing. The novelty preserves the relationship.

7. Earning the spin — the qualifying thresholds

Two ways to earn a spin, both designed to be achievable but not automatic:

Individual spin:

- Three consecutive closed deals — back to back.
- Pushes the rep to qualify bookings well. One bad booking in the middle of three resets the run.
- Achievable in a strong week. Hard but not unreasonable.

Team spin:

- Ten closed deals across the team in one week.

- Pairs lead-gen and closers — they win or lose together.
- Encourages the lead-gen team to hand over bookings the closers can actually close.

Why two paths matter — the individual rep who has a great week is rewarded directly; the team that performs as a unit is rewarded together. Different incentive geometries for different behaviours.

8. The recruitment story — what to tell new hires

The competition isn't just an internal mechanic. It's a recruitment asset. Reps having conversations with potential new hires — at family events, at the gym, at church, anywhere — should be able to describe the structure in a way that makes the role sound concrete and attainable.

The talking points for a recruitment conversation:

1. Base wage + per-booking bonus + per-deal bonus. Three layers of income from day one.
2. The per-booking bonus is the safety net for the learning curve. You make money while you're learning.
3. The per-deal bonus scales with the deal size. Big deals pay big bonuses.
4. Hit three deals back to back, you spin the wheel. The wheel pays cash, prizes, experiences, or extra commission.
5. The team also wins together. Hit ten deals as a team in a week, everyone gets a shot at a team-level reward.

> *"What's the highest someone has made on bookings alone in a single week? You should know that number off the top of your head. That number is your recruitment pitch."*

9. The leadership principles underneath

The competition redesign sits on top of three leadership principles that shape every incentive decision.

Give people what they want first.

The philosophy that drives the design. Reps wanted bigger deal bonuses. The redesign delivers that — and trusts that the larger structural goal (more closed deals, more recruitment momentum) follows. The opposite approach — extracting maximum margin from the incentive — gets short-term cost savings and long-term attrition.

Build the system for the next ten hires.

The current team will absorb new reps continually. The incentive structure must work as well for a brand-new rep on day one as it does for a veteran rep on day 500. That's why the booking bonus stays — not because today's reps need it, but because tomorrow's do.

10x comes from leverage, not skill.

A rep who gets twice as good at closing earns roughly twice as much. A rep who learns how to onboard and develop other reps earns ten times as much. The competition is designed to make the agency a place where good reps want to bring people in — because the structure makes onboarding profitable for everyone.

> *"Your future income isn't built on you getting better at closing. It's built on you getting better at recruiting. The bonus structure has to support that — not just your weekly close count."*

10. Implementation notes

6. Run the new structure for one month. Track booking volume, deal close rate, deal size, and rep retention.
7. Communicate the change clearly — every rep should be able to explain the new structure to a new hire on day one.
8. Post the wheel reward list visibly. Reps need to see what's on it to engage with it.
9. Track top numbers publicly — top week, top day, top deal value. The competition only works when reps know what they're chasing.
10. After one month, review with the team. Adjust the wheel mix, the qualifying thresholds, or the bonus sliding scale based on what's actually happening.
11. Keep the upside open. Never cap a reward. Always make it easier to lift the bonus than to lower it.

THE ONE-LINER Shift the incentive to deals. Keep the booking safety net for recruitment. Spin the wheel for the highs. Build for the next ten hires, not just today's team.